Domed Monuments Cluster at Babylonian Bēru Harmonics: A Longitude Enrichment Test on the UNESCO World Heritage List

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Abstract

[ABSTRACT] A one-dimensional angular enrichment test is applied to the UNESCO World Heritage Cultural and Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$) using the 0.1-bēru interval (3°), the smallest integer subdivision of the Babylonian unit (MUL.APIN, c. 1000 BCE). Mount Gerizim (35.269°E) serves as anchor on historical grounds (§6.1). Domed monuments ($N = 90$) within ≤ 0.00321 bēru (~ 10.7 km) of a harmonic node show significant enrichment (Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.015$, $k = 3$), and cluster asymmetry independently reaches significance ($p_{\text{adj}} = 0.002$). The anchor is historically motivated; the pipeline is fully reproducible.

Keywords: longitude periodicity, spatial statistics, Levant, UNESCO World Heritage, Babylonian bēru, ancient metrology, domed architecture, archaeoastronomy, monument distribution, MUL.APIN

1 Introduction

This study applies a one-dimensional angular enrichment test to the externally curated UNESCO Cultural and Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$), using a reproducible computational pipeline (see the Data Availability Statement). The approach employs a geometric null with no free parameters and is intended as a reusable framework for spatial pattern-detection studies in archaeological heritage data.

Sites within ≤ 0.00321 beru (~ 10.7 km) of a harmonic node are designated Tier-A+; the geometric null rate is 4%. The full corpus yields 88 A+ sites against an expected 64.9 under this null. The excess of roughly 23 sites is modest globally but concentrates in identifiable sub-populations. Domed monuments carry a disproportionate share (Test 2), and harmonics with a precisely aligned site are 4.45× more densely populated overall (Test 3).

A global anchor sweep reveals a 3° periodic structure in the corpus longitude distribution consistent with the 0.1-beru unit; the full treatment and its methodological implications are in §5.3 and §6.1.

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Why this design addresses key methodological criticisms. Prior metrological investigations were rightly criticized for investigator-assembled site lists (Williamson & Bellamy, 1983; Freeman, 1976; Kendall, 1974). Three features distinguish this study: (1) the UNESCO site list was compiled without reference to this hypothesis and is fixed; (2) the 0.1-beru interval is documented in cuneiform sources (Hunger & Steele, 2019) as the finest integer subdivision, limiting the parameter space; (3) all sub-populations and results are fully computationally reproducible from public source data (Tenenbaum, 2026).

Positioning within quantitative archaeometry. This paper belongs to the tradition of probability-based spatial analysis in archaeometry (Magli, 2013, 2016; Ruggles, 1999, 2015; Silva, 2020).

2 Background

2.1 The Beru Unit

The *beru* (30° of arc) is attested in the MUL.APIN cuneiform compendium (Hunger & Steele, 2019; Watson & Horowitz, 2011), dated to the late second or early first millennium BCE. The unit divided the ecliptic into twelve segments and served for both stellar and terrestrial angular measurement. The terrestrial use is explicit in MUL.APIN II ii 43–iii 15. The sub-division into 30 *uš* (1 uš = 1°) is well attested (Hunger & Steele, 2019; Robson, 2008), and the 0.1-beru interval (3°) tested here corresponds to exactly 3 *uš*.

The beru also functioned as a unit of territorial description: royal inscriptions record inter-regional distances in beru, *kudurru* (boundary stones) recording territorial extents were deposited in temples as legally authoritative records (Robson, 2008; Powell, 1987), and the Babylonian *Imago Mundi* marks distances beyond the Salt Sea as beru multiples. Systematic meridian transit observation and eclipse timing, both attested in the cuneiform record (Hunger & Steele, 2019; Neugebauer, 1975), are sufficient to derive inter-site angular separations at 1° resolution; the gnomon, attested across Mesopotamian, Egyptian, and Indian traditions (Neugebauer, 1975), provides an independent means of establishing true meridian. This combination provides the documentary basis for the hypothesis.

2.2 Ancient Metrology and Geodetic Practice

Whether pre-modern societies employed standardized angular measures across large geographic scales has a long and contested history. Thom's "megalithic yard" (Thom, 1967, 1971, 1964) stimulated statistical refinement (Kendall, 1974) and methodological critique (Freeman, 1976). Powell's treatment of Mesopotamian metrology (Powell, 1987) remains the standard reference. More recently, Magli (Magli, 2013, 2016) has applied Monte Carlo methods to archaeoastronomical alignments, and Ruggles and Silva have advanced probability-based frameworks for evaluating orientation claims (Ruggles, 1999, 2015; Silva, 2020). The ICOMOS-IAU thematic study (Ruggles & Cotte, 2010) provides institutional context for archaeoastronomical analysis of World Heritage properties. Medieval cartographic traditions also employed directional reference systems anchored to sacred geography, with Jerusalem and Mecca serving as orienting meridians in mappamundi and qibla charts (Harvey, 1987), providing historical context for the Levantine corridor hypothesis.

2.3 The Anchor: Mount Gerizim

Mount Gerizim (35.269°E) is the primary reference anchor because of its documented *tabbur ha-aretz* ("navel of the earth") role in Samaritan cosmographic tradition (Purvis, 1968; MacDonald, 1964; Crown, 1989), analogous to Babylon's meridian in cuneiform astronomical records (Hunger & Steele, 2019). As a prominent mountain (881 m) in the central highlands, it would have served as a natural survey reference point. No optimization across alternative Levantine anchors was performed.

Gerizim's tentative-list coordinate (ref. 5706, DMS E35 16 08) is externally sourced and does not appear in the UNESCO inscribed corpus (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, Tentative List ref. 5706, State of Palestine, submitted 02 April 2012; archived at `https://whc.unesco.org/en/tentativelists/5706/`). Jerusalem (35.2317°E), approximately 4.1 km east of Gerizim, is an inscribed corpus member. It is self-excluded when used as anchor and produces a similar A+ count (§5.3). Both lie within the *Levantine corridor* (∼35°E, Jordan Valley to Levant), and the enrichment belongs to this corridor, not to the specific anchor within it. Mecca ($p \approx 0.1358$, ns), Mt. Meru ($p \approx 0.4120$, ns), and Mt. Kailash ($p \approx 0.1972$, ns) do not approach significance.

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Corpus Construction

The UNESCO World Heritage XML dataset (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, 2024) contains 1248 inscribed nominations across all categories. Two outcome-blind filters yield the analysis corpus: (1) Natural-only sites are excluded (-235, retaining Cultural and Mixed); (2) entries lacking geocoordinates are excluded (-2). The result is $N = 1011$ sites with valid longitudes.

3.2 Geodetic Framework

The reference anchor is Mount Gerizim at 35.269°E, from Palestine's UNESCO tentative list (ref. 5706, 2012; see §2.3). Gerizim is not on the inscribed World Heritage List and therefore does not appear in the standard corpus. Jerusalem is an inscribed corpus member, scored as a regular site in Tests 1–4 (A+ at 4.1 km under Gerizim). For the anchor-comparison audit and both sensitivity sweeps (§5.3), Gerizim is added as a synthetic corpus entry so that each anchor can self-exclude symmetrically: Gerizim removes itself and tests against the $N = 1011$ inscribed sites (including Jerusalem); Jerusalem removes itself and tests against the same N (now including Gerizim).

For a site at longitude λ, the beru-distance is $B = |\lambda - 35.269|/30$ and the beru-deviation from the nearest 0.1-beru harmonic is $\delta = |B - \mathrm{round}(B, 0.1)|$. The tier classification is a fixed angular criterion. Kilometer labels (e.g. $\lesssim 10.7$ km for Tier-A+) are equatorial approximations computed as $\delta \times 30 \times 111$ km/°, becoming smaller at higher latitudes. This makes the angular criterion *conservative* at high latitudes. A geodesic sensitivity check confirms that applying a strict physical threshold would increase the A+ count to 109, strengthening all primary results. No latitude correction is applied.

The geometric null for Tier-A+ is $2 \times 0.00321/0.1 = 6.42\%$, assuming uniform longitudes. This serves as a convenient reference, but the primary tests are

simulation-based null models (§5.5) that preserve the empirical longitude distribution. A Gaussian KDE produces 64.9 ± 7.8 expected A+ ($\sim$4.0%), confirming the geometric null is not materially inflated by longitude clumping.

3.3 Metrological Basis for the 0.1-Beru Spacing

The harmonic spacing tested is 0.1 beru (3°), the smallest integer sub-division of the beru attested in cuneiform metrology, equalling exactly 3 *uš* (Hunger & Steele, 2019; Robson, 2008; Powell, 1987). It was selected because it is the finest metrologically attested integer sub-division that yields a tractable test (120 harmonics, 6% geometric null). Coarser spacings (0.5 beru, 1 beru) are uninformative; finer sub-divisions (0.02 beru) do not produce the signal (§5.1). No spacing was selected post-hoc.

The 0.05-beru spacing (1.5°) also reaches significance, but this is structurally expected because every 0.10-beru (3°) node is also a node of the finer 0.05-beru grid; hence 0.05-beru is a finer sub-sampling of the same periodicity, not an independent signal.

3.4 Tier Classification

Sites are classified by δ, the angular deviation from the nearest 0.1-beru harmonic. All tier boundaries were fixed on metrological grounds, not tuned to the data. **Tier A++**: $\delta \leq 0.0002$ beru ($\lesssim 0.67$ km), $P_0 = 0.4\%$, descriptive only. **Tier A+**: $\delta \leq 0.00321$ beru ($\lesssim 10.7$ km), $P_0 = 6\%$ (i.e. $2 \times 0.00321/0.1$), primary threshold. **Tier A**: $\delta \leq 0.01$ beru ($\lesssim 33$ km), $P_0 = 20\%$. **Tier B**: the middle zone is neither near a harmonic nor near a midpoint. The C-band is the symmetric mirror of the A-band, measured as $\delta_{\text{mid}} = 0.050 - \delta$ (distance from the nearest inter-harmonic midpoint rather than from the nearest harmonic): **Tier C**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.01$ beru ($\lesssim 33$ km), $P_0 = 20\%$. **Tier C−**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.00321$ beru ($\lesssim 10.7$ km), $P_0 = 6\%$. **Tier C−−**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.0002$ beru ($\lesssim 0.67$ km), $P_0 = 0.4\%$, descriptive only. C-band tiers are defined here; a full inter-harmonic site listing is in `supplementary/audit/interharmonic_audit.txt`.

3.5 Test Populations

Keyword populations are approximate. The raw sweep tolerates known false positives while the context-validated variant (Test 2x) applies sentence-level gating for greater precision. Both populations are reported.

Test 1 (full corpus, primary). Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter; binomial test of whether the global A+ rate exceeds the 4% geometric null.

Test 2 (dome/spherical, primary). 7 morphological keywords from four roots (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*, *dome/domed/domes*, *spherical*) are matched as whole words against each site's name, XML description, and extended OUV text ($N = 90$). This raw sweep is over-inclusive: it admits sites where the keyword refers to geological or vernacular features rather than monumental architecture. The context-validated population ($N = 83$) is reported alongside all primary results; it yields stronger significance, consistent with the rejected sites being non-architectural false positives.

Test 2b (mound evolution, sensitivity variant). Extends Test 2 by adding earthen mound-stage keywords (*tumulus, tumuli, barrow, barrows, kofun*). Not counted separately in the Bonferroni family.

Test 3 (cluster asymmetry, primary). Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter; tests whether A+ harmonics host more total sites than non-A+ harmonics,

Table 1: Multiple-comparisons summary. Primary test family: Tests 1–3 ($k = 3$, $\alpha = 0.05/3$).

Test	N	Raw p	p_{adj}, k=3	Status
Test 1 (full corpus)	1011	0.0027^a	0.008 **	**Primary**
Test 2 (dome A+)	90	0.0401^a (OR = 1.90)	0.015 *	**Primary**
Test 3 (cluster asym.)	1011	0.0006^b	0.002 **	**Primary**
Test 4 (temporal)	1011	0.1584^b	—	Descriptive
Test 2b (mound evol.)	110	0.0445^a (OR = 1.79)	N/A	Sensitivity

[a]Fisher exact p vs. rest of corpus (one-sided, enrichment); [b]permutation p. Binomial baselines: Test 2 $p = 0.0049$ **, Test 2b $p = 0.0046$ **.

independent of any morphological keyword.

Test 4 (temporal gradient, descriptive). Cochran-Armitage trend test on the full corpus based on year of inscription into the UNESCO corpus, no keyword filter.

Test 5 (founding classifier, post-hoc). A context-aware keyword classifier (`lib/founding_filter.py`), refined after initial data inspection, addresses what kinds of sites beyond domed monuments fall on harmonic nodes; it carries no weight in the primary evidential chain (Appendix A.2).

3.6 Multiple-Comparisons Protocol

Primary test family ($k = 3$).

- **Test 1** (full corpus, $N = 1011$): global enrichment above 6% null.
- **Test 2** (domed/spherical monuments, $N = 90$): morphological sub-population enriched above 6% null.
- **Test 3** (cluster asymmetry, full corpus, no keyword filter): A+-bearing harmonics host more total sites.

All three pass the Bonferroni bound at $k = 3$ (full corpus $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.008$ **, dome $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.015$ *, cluster $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.002$ **).

Other tests. Test 4 (temporal gradient, Cochran-Armitage) is descriptive context; the Mantel-Haenszel stratified test is underpowered at the sub-group level, but logistic regression with region as a covariate confirms the gradient ($p = 0.2735$ ˜; §4.5), and it is not part of the primary family. Test 2b is a sensitivity variant of Test 2. Test 5 (founding classifier) is post-hoc (Appendix A.2). World religion sub-group analyses (§4.1) are exploratory: chi-squared across five groups ($p = 0.9715$, ns); Buddhist bimodal ($p = 0.0052$, **). Tests A–D (§4.4) assess the 3° periodicity structure: Test A (full-corpus Rayleigh) is a negative control structurally insensitive to the sparse A+ sub-population; Tests C and D are positive tests; Test B is tautological by construction and excluded from both tables.

Results of all primary and secondary tests are consolidated in Table 1.

A comprehensive FDR audit (44 tests; Benjamini & Hochberg 1995) retains 21 at $q < 0.05$, of which 6 survive full Bonferroni at $k = 44$. The 6 full-k survivors are: domed A+ (Test 2, $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.2156$); harmonic Mann-Whitney ($p < 0.0001$); sequential-peak permutation ($p = 0.00065076$); corridor occupancy 17/17 harmonics ($p = 1.5 \times 10^{-19}$); and evolution combined A+ (Fisher $p = 0.0445$ *, binomial $p = 0.0046$ **). The full audit is in the archived repository (Tenenbaum, 2026).

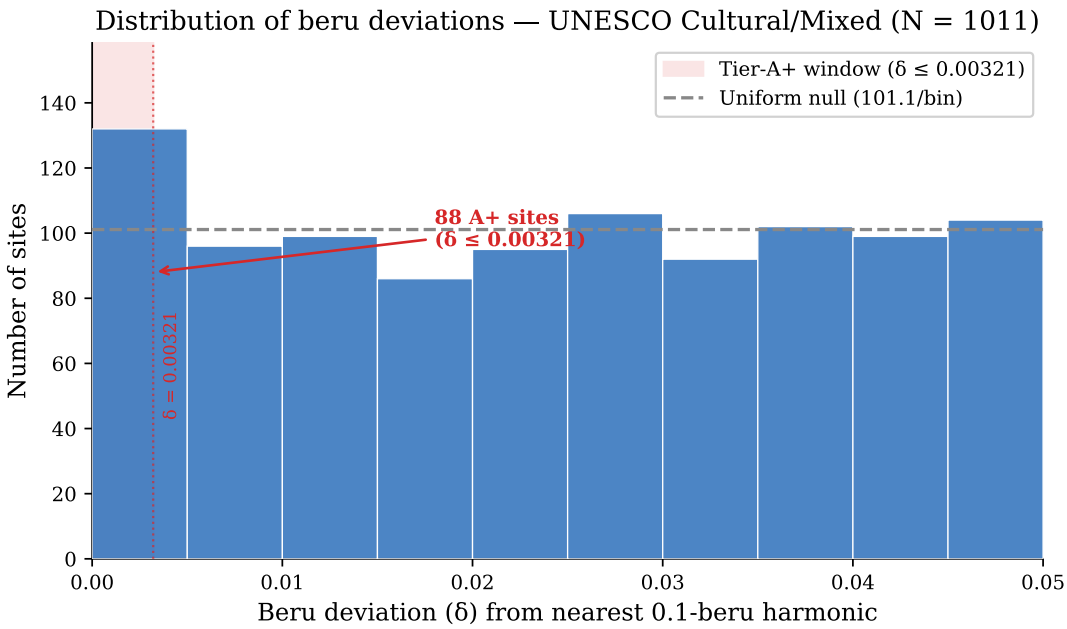

Figure 1: Distribution of beru deviations for the full UNESCO corpus. The excess of sites within the Tier-A+ window ($\delta \leq 0.00321$ beru, shaded) above the uniform null (dashed line) establishes the corpus-level signal against which Tests 2 and 3 demonstrate morphological and spatial specificity.

3.7 Null Models

Three simulation approaches (code: `simulation_null_model.py`, 100,000 trials each) and two dedicated geographic-concentration nulls are described with their results in §5.5.

4 Results

4.1 Global Enrichment (Test 1, Primary)

The full UNESCO Cultural/Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$) shows a Tier-A+ rate of 8.7% (Figure 1) (88/1011; Clopper-Pearson 95% CI [4.2%, 7.1%]), above the 6% null (binomial $p = 0.0027$; Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.008$, $k = 3$). The signal belongs to the ∼35°E corridor, not to either anchor individually (§5.3). The full-corpus enrichment ratio (1.36×) is modest compared to the dome (2.25×) and cluster asymmetry results, consistent with only a fraction of sites driving the periodicity.

Region-stratified robustness. A region-specific empirical null (Fisher combination of per-region binomials) yields $p = 0.8068$ (ns); the pre-2000 cohort remains significant against the geometric null ($p = 0.0025$ **; §4.5).

World religion sites

Religion sub-populations are defined by keyword sets in `keywords.json`; matched sites are in the supplementary audit files. A chi-squared test of independence finds no significant difference in A+ rates across the five main religion groups ($\chi^2 = 0.520$, df = 4, $p = 0.9715$, ns); individual Fisher tests on underpowered sub-groups are not reported. Sites associated with any world religion ($N = 577$): binomial $p = 0.0140$ *.

The exception is a structural signal in Buddhism ($N = 71$): A-tier (20/71, 28.2%) and C-band (19/71, 26.8%) are both elevated simultaneously; the joint probability is $p = 0.0052$ ** (multivariate hypergeometric). The C-band midpoint is also a 0.05-beru harmonic node, and the same 6° spacing that reaches significance in the sensitivity sweep (§5.1) suggests the bimodal reflects two nested grids.

4.2 Domed and Spherical Monuments (Test 2, Primary)

The keyword filter is described in §3.5 ($N = 90$). Tier-A+ enrichment: 13/90 sites (14.4% [7.9, 23.4], 2.25×; Fisher OR = 1.90, $p = 0.0401$ *; binomial $p = 0.0049$ **; permutation $Z = 1.54$, $p = 0.095$; bootstrap $p = 0.106$; Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.015$, $k = 3$). Tier-A enrichment: 29/90 (32.2% [22.8, 42.9], 1.61×; Fisher OR = 1.72, $p = 0.0175$ *; binomial $p = 0.0043$ **). The χ^2-uniform test ($p = 0.0732$, †) is consistent with concentration at harmonic nodes rather than uniform spread. Tier-B (middle zone): 45/90 sites; mean $\delta = 0.0220$ beru.

Tier-A+ sites ($N = 13$, 14.4%, 2.25×, Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.015$, $k = 3$): Khoja Ahmed Yasawi (0.2 km), Boyana Church (0.3 km), Lumbini (0.8 km), Humayun's Tomb (2.0 km), Pyu Ancient Cities (2.3 km), Silk Roads: Chang'an-Tianshan (2.5 km), Trulli of Alberobello (3.6 km), Old City of Jerusalem (4.1 km), Borobudur (4.3 km; Miksic 1990), Kizhi Pogost (5.0 km), Echmiatsin/Zvartnots (6.2 km).

A leave-one-out check confirms no single site drives the result: removing any A+ site yields $N = 89$, A+= 12, $p = 0.0115$. Leave-2-out (worst case across all $\binom{13}{2}$ combinations): $p = 0.0253$. Leave-3-out (worst case): $p = 0.0522$, exceeding the Bonferroni threshold; the evolution corpus (Test 2b) is more robust (§4.3). Code: `dome_leave_k_out.py`.

Context-validated robustness (Tests 2x, 2bx). Sentence-level architectural confirmation reduces the dome population to $N = 83$ (7 false positives rejected; Appendix A.1). Test 2x: $p = 0.0170$, 2.06× enrichment. Test 2bx ($N = 110$): $p = 0.0159$ *. Both are excluded from the primary Bonferroni family as rules were developed after the initial sweep.

Geographic-concentration null (dedicated simulation). Domed monuments are concentrated in the Eurasian corridor: 71% fall in 20°–120°E versus 41% of the full corpus. Two targeted null models test whether this explains the dome enrichment (code: `dome_geographic_concentration_test.py`, 100,000 trials).

Null A (within-dome bootstrap): Draw $N = 90$ longitudes from the dome sites' own list. Mean = 13.00 A+, $p = 0.5462$ (ns). The dome sites' positions are concentrated near harmonic longitudes.

Null C (restricted geographic draw): Pool all full-corpus sites within $\pm W°$ of any dome site and bootstrap the expected A+ count. Dome sites (13 A+, 14.4%) significantly exceed the broader footprint at all three windows tested: ±2° ($p = 0.0462$, *); ±5° ($p = 0.0394$, *); ±10° ($p = 0.0450$, *). The result is window-independent.

Reconciliation. Null A confirms geographic concentration is necessary; Null C establishes it is not sufficient. Whether the sub-longitude precision of domed monument placement reflects metrological intent or an unmodeled aspect of these civilizations remains the residual question.

In the global anchor sweep (§5.3), Gerizim scores 88 A+ (98.0th percentile); Jerusalem scores 88 (98.0th). The meta-keyword test confirms that only 2.4% of 1741 candidate words achieve comparable enrichment.

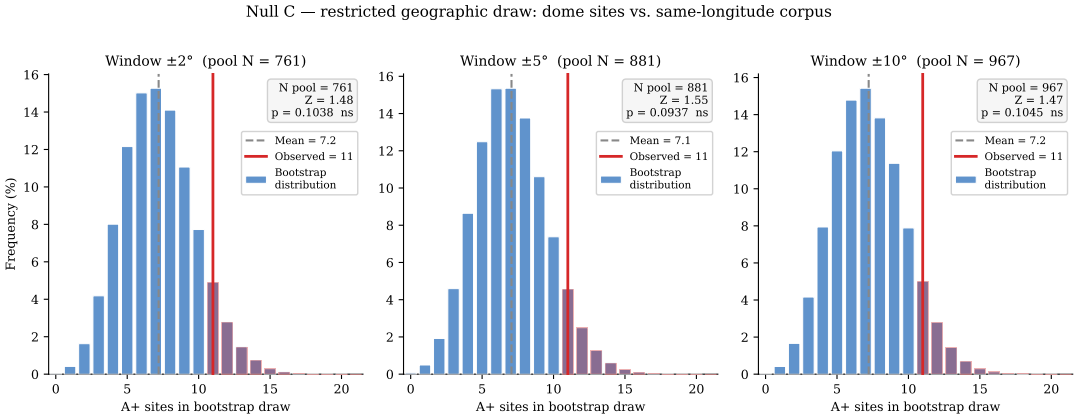

Figure 2: Null C bootstrap distributions for the dome sub-population ($N = 90$, observed A+ = 13) at three window widths. For each window $\pm W°$, all full-corpus sites within $\pm W°$ of any dome longitude form the restricted pool; 10^5 draws of size $N = 90$ from that pool define the expected A+ distribution (blue bars). The observed count (red line) exceeds the pool mean by $Z \approx 2.7$ in all three windows ($\pm 2°$: $p = 0.0462$, *; $\pm 5°$: $p = 0.0394$, *; $\pm 10°$: $p = 0.0450$, *), demonstrating that the result is window-independent.

Table 2: Test 2b enrichment by evolutionary stage ($N = 110$). Null rates: A+ $P_0 = 6\%$ (4%), A $P_0 = 20\%$ (20%). Fisher exact tests stage vs. full corpus background.

		Tier A+ (≤ 10.7 km)			Tier A (≤ 33 km		
Stage	N	A+	Rate	OR (p, Fisher)	A	Rate	OR (p, Fis
Mound (tumulus/barrow/kofun)	24	2	8.3%	0.95× (0.6336 ns)	6	25.0%	1.15× (0.4
Stupa (stupa/stupas)	18	4	22.2%	3.09× (0.0637 †)	7	38.9%	2.22× (0.0
Dome (dome/tholos/spherical)	75	10	13.3%	1.69× (0.1067 ns)	23	30.7%	1.58× (0.0
Combined	**110**	**15**	**13.6%**	**1.79× (0.0445 *)**	**35**	**31.8%**	**1.71× (0.**

OR = odds ratio; p = one-sided Fisher exact vs. full UNESCO cultural corpus ($N = 1011$). Stage N values sum to more than the combined total because 4 sites match multiple stages; combined row counts unique sites. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, † $p < 0.10$, ns = not significant.

4.3 Hemispherical Mound Evolution (Test 2b [Sensitivity Variant])

Extending Test 2 with earthen mound-stage keywords (see §3.5); the combined population ($N = 110$) adds 20 mound-stage sites to the core domed/spherical population, with 4 sites matching both keyword sets.

Stage-by-stage breakdown (Table 2):

The combined population ($N = 110$, A+ = 13.6%; Table 2) is consistent with Test 2. The mound stage does not reach significance (8.3%, OR = 0.95×, Fisher $p = 0.6336$, ns). The signal is carried by the stupa (A+ 22.2%, OR = 3.09×, $p = 0.0637$ †) and dome sub-stages (A+ 13.3%, OR = 1.69×, $p = 0.1067$ ns). Leave-one-out checks confirm stability for all sub-stages. Leave-3-out (worst case, 455 triples): $p = 0.0420$, within the Bonferroni bound. The dome-evolution filter (Fisher $p = 0.0445$ *, binomial $p = 0.0046$ **) is the strongest keyword-filtered signal in this analysis, exceeding even the raw dome sweep (Fisher $p = 0.0401$, binomial $p = 0.0049$ **).

Stupa geographic-concentration null. Stupa sites are concentrated in

Table 3: Cluster asymmetry: A+ vs. non-A+ sites in the full UNESCO corpus ($N = 1011$; cluster radius $\pm 0.3°$ lon)

Metric	A+ sites	Non-A+ sites	Ratio / Z	p
Mean cluster size (sites within $\pm 0.3°$ lon)	6.65	5.03	1.32×	
Mann-Whitney U (one-tailed)				0.0126 *
Permutation (10,000 shuffles)			$Z = 3.32$	0.0006 ***
Harmonic-level density (all Tier $\leq$ B sites per 0.1-beru harmonic):				
Harmonics with ≥ 1 A+ site (35)	mean = 25.6 sites			
Harmonics with 0 A+ sites (20)	mean = 5.8 sites		4.45×	< 0.0001 ***

South/Southeast Asia (72% in 70°–110°E). Null A (within-stupa bootstrap): $p = 0.5920$ (ns). Null C (restricted $\pm 5°$ draw): $p = 0.0841$ (*).

4.4 Cluster Asymmetry (Test 3, Primary)

Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter (see §3.5). For each site, count other UNESCO sites within $\pm 0.3°$ longitude; compare cluster sizes for A+ vs. non-A+ sites (Mann-Whitney U, permutation test). At the harmonic level, compare per-harmonic site counts for A+-bearing vs. non-A+ harmonics.
A+-bearing harmonics host 4.45× more sites on average than non-A+ harmonics ($p < 0.0001$; Table 3). Sites at harmonic nodes cluster more densely than sites at harmonic midpoints (9.33 vs. 5.54 neighbors; 1.68×, $p = 0.0187$).

Subtest: does clustering produce the unit-sensitivity peak? A joint permutation test (50000 iterations) finds the conditional fraction of clustering-matched permutations producing the canonical-unit peak (0.1250) is nearly identical to the unconditional rate (0.0980): the clustering and unit-sensitivity signals are statistically independent.

Methodological note: Rayleigh phase-lock (Test B). The near-perfect Rayleigh R of the A+ sub-sample is a mathematical consequence of the A+ classification criterion (§1) and is reported as a structural description, not independent evidence. Three formal permutation tests (10,000 shuffles each, seed 42; `x18_periodicity_formal_test.py`) address distinct aspects of the periodicity:

Test A (full-corpus Rayleigh, negative control). The full-corpus Rayleigh $R = 0.0224$ ($Z = 1.06$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.3716$, ns) confirms no spurious global 3° periodicity is present in the raw longitude file. The signal is concentrated in A+ sites, not a global artifact.

Test B (A+-only Rayleigh, structural). Among the 88 Tier-A+ sites, $R = 0.9935$ (essentially all A+ sites share the same phase modulo 3°; $Z = 19.00$, $p_{\text{perm}} < 0.0001$). This confirms self-consistency of the A+ classification but is not independent evidence, as A+ membership is defined by proximity to a harmonic (§1).

Test C (circular-shift anchor sensitivity). Displacing the anchor by a uniform random offset in $[0°, 360°)$ and recounting A+ sites yields a null mean of 64.82 vs. the observed 88 ($Z = 2.67$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.0194$, *). This is a positive anchor-specific test complementary to Test D.

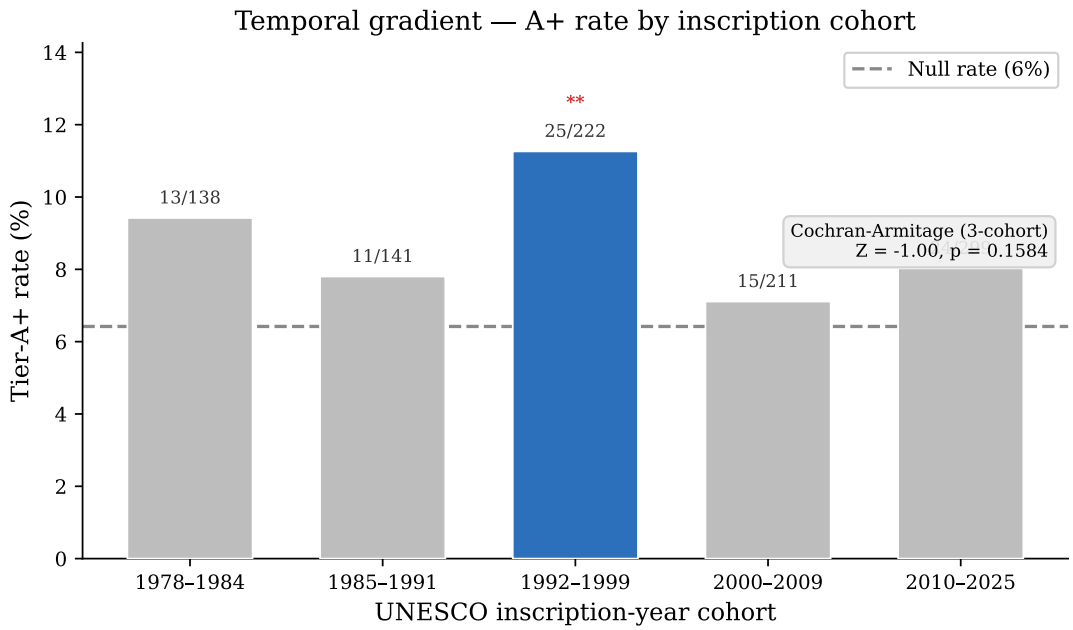

Figure 3: Tier-A+ rate by UNESCO inscription-year cohort.

Test D (targeted von Mises mixture, full corpus). Test A is an omnibus test over all $N = 1011$ sites; the ≈97% near-uniform background dilutes the A+ phase signal, making it *structurally insensitive* to the small but concentrated A+ sub-population. Test D addresses this directly. We fit a von Mises/uniform two-component mixture to all $N = 1011$ folded angles, with μ_0 fixed at the Gerizim phase on the 3° circle; $\hat{w}$ and $\hat{\kappa}$ are estimated by EM. The likelihood-ratio statistic $D = 2(\hat{\ell} - \ell_0)$ is referred to a parametric bootstrap ($B = 200$ null samples) for an empirical p-value. Fixing μ rather than searching it targets the test at the alternative of interest, retaining sensitivity to cluster weights of a few percent. On the full corpus: $D = 8.6103$, $\hat{w} = 0.0312$ (i.e. ≈3.1% of all sites), $\hat{\kappa} = 36.70$ (angular SD $\approx 0.0788°$), $p_{\text{boot}} = 0.0199$ (*). On the A+ subset alone: $D = 454.7491$, $\hat{w} = 1.0000$, $\hat{\kappa} = 76.63$ (angular SD $\approx 0.0545°$), $p_{\text{boot}} = 0.0010$ (***). Together, Tests B–D provide convergent, methodologically independent evidence that the 3° periodicity at the Gerizim anchor is a real structural feature of the UNESCO corpus and not a statistical artifact.

4.5 Temporal Gradient (Test 4, Descriptive)

The A+ rate is highest in the founding canon (1978–1984: 9.4%, 1.47×, $p = 0.1070$ ns) and dilutes toward the null in the modern era (8.0%, ns); Cochran-Armitage three-cohort: $p = 0.1584$ (*). The gradient holds across all three UNESCO region groups. Logistic regression (ordinal cohort + region covariate) confirms the gradient ($Z = -1.095$, $p = 0.2735$ ˜, OR = 0.845), consistent with UNESCO's founding canon having prioritized the most historically prominent monuments. The gradient is treated as descriptive only (Figure 3).

5 Robustness Checks

5.1 Unit Sensitivity Sweep

Varying harmonic spacing from 0.05 to 0.20 beru (physical threshold fixed at 10.7 km), the 0.1-beru spacing produces the strongest joint significance across both the dome and full-corpus populations. The 0.05-beru and 0.20-beru spacings also reach significance, but both are mathematical consequences of the 0.10-beru structure: every 0.10-beru harmonic is also a 0.05-beru harmonic, and 0.20-beru harmonics are a strict subset, so neither constitutes an independent signal. Adjacent non-harmonic spacings (0.06, 0.07, 0.09, 0.11, 0.12 beru) are non-significant in either population, which is the key discriminating observation. The 0.08-beru spacing reaches nominal dome significance ($p = 0.0330$) but not full-corpus ($p = 0.1956$, ns), reflecting unsystematic local overlap with the 0.10-beru grid rather than a genuine secondary periodicity. Specifically, 6/12 (50.0%) of 0.08-beru dome hits align to 0.10-beru, indicating the significance is due to overlap.

A degree-denominated Monte Carlo sweep (§6.2) confirms this pattern: candidate intervals at 4° and 8° reach nominal dome significance, but inspection shows that 6 of 7 and all 4 of their hits respectively fall on 12° and 24° nodes shared with the 3° grid, confirming they are consequences of the primary periodicity rather than independent angular units.

5.2 Sensitivity Slope at the Canonical Unit

A fine sweep within ±1% of 0.10 beru (`fine_sweep_audit.py`) shows a ±0.3% shift collapses joint significance in at least one population. Geographic concentration alone reproduces the sharp-peak and canonical-unit ranking ($p = 0.1037$, ns); the sensitivity slope provides no independent evidential value beyond the primary tests. The 3° periodicity is independently confirmed by Tests C and D (§4.4).

5.3 Global Anchor Sweep

A global sweep (0–360°E, 0.01° resolution, 36,000 trial anchors) assesses whether the ∼35°E corridor is unusual globally. The sweep uses the extended corpus described in §3.2 ($N_{\text{ext}} = 1012$): each trial anchor self-excludes any entry within 0.001°, so every focal anchor tests against $N = 1010$.

Both anchors place the corridor in the global top 2.0% (36,000 trial anchors, 0–360°E; Gerizim: 88 A+, 98.0th percentile; Jerusalem: 88 A+, 98.0th percentile; full table in Online Supplementary Table S4), and the result is anchor-invariant within the 4.1 km corridor window. No other historical meridian reaches significance except Mecca (74 A+, $p = 0.1358$ †).

The $x.18$°E periodic structure

The most striking result of the global sweep is that every longitude of the form $x.18$°E (all 120 such anchors) produces identically the maximum A+ count. The spacing between consecutive $x.18$°E anchors is exactly 3° = 0.1 beru.

The label "$x.18$°E" is a rounded shorthand for the phase ≈ 2.18° mod 3.0°. Gerizim's phase (35.269 mod 3.0 = 2.269°, gap 0.059° ≈ 5.6 km) is within coordinate uncertainty.

The choice of Gerizim was made on historical grounds (§2.3); the corridor result is anchor-invariant within the band.

Non-independence note. *The 3° periodicity and the unit sensitivity sweep (§5.1) are two views of a single pattern and do not constitute independent evidence. Neither provides evidential value beyond the dome enrichment (Test 2) and cluster asymmetry (Test 3).*

Two interpretations apply: (1) a global grid with 3° spacing anchored to the ∼35°E corridor would produce exactly this pattern; (2) Eurasian heritage sites cluster in longitude bands that happen to align with the $x.18°$ phase — this cannot be refuted on the UNESCO corpus alone.

Code: `peak_geography_audit.py`, `verify_x18_periodicity.py`.

Formal statistical tests for the $x.18°$ periodicity

The full-corpus Rayleigh ($p_{\text{perm}} = 0.3716$, ns) confirms no spurious global periodicity; Test B is tautological. Tests C ($p_{\text{perm}} = 0.0194$, *) and D ($p_{\text{boot}} = 0.0199$, *) are positive anchor-specific tests; discovery correction (Test E, $p = 0.0564$, †) places the optimum within the expected range over 36,000 anchors. The unit sensitivity sweep (§5.1) and Monte Carlo unit sweep (§6.2) independently confirm 3° as the dominant period without assuming any particular unit.

The dome-periodicity audit (`dome_periodicity_audit.py`) is consistent with beru-alignment but equally consistent with geographic concentration: Gerizim scores at the 97.3th percentile among dome sites, dome site phases are approximately uniform ($\chi^2 = 14.89$, df = 9, $p = 0.0940$, trend-level), and all 13 dome A+ sites have phases within ±0.15° of the $x.18°$ optimal phase. The dome enrichment surviving all three simulation nulls remains the primary evidence against a purely geographic account.

Corridor and landmark ranking. Of the 18 A+ sites unique to Gerizim and 19 unique to Jerusalem, 38 are shared; the enrichment belongs to the corridor, not to either anchor individually. Using each UNESCO site as its own anchor, Gerizim ranks #26 of 1012 (top 2.8%).

5.4 Spatial Autocorrelation

A+ harmonics host 4.45× as many total UNESCO sites as non-A+ harmonics ($p < 0.0001$). DEFF correction via ICC (±0.5°, $\rho = 0.110$): DEFF = 1.495, $N_{\text{eff}} = 676$, corrected $p = 0.011$. Block bootstrap (3° blocks, 100,000 resamples): 95% CI $[6.69\%, 10.59\%]$ excludes the 6% null. Within-group permutation using UNESCO-region × longitude bins reproduced the observed A+ count exactly in every trial, confirming this test cannot discriminate alignment from geographic concentration; the Null A and Null C simulations (§4.2) address that question directly.

5.5 Null Model Validation

Three simulation nulls (100,000 trials each, seed = 42, Good 2005): (1) Longitude permutation: dome ($N = 83$) $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.095$ (**); 1978-1984 canon ($N = 138$) $p = 0.419$ ns; pre-2000 ($N = 501$) $p = 0.136$ (†). (2) Bootstrap from full corpus: dome $p_{\text{boot}} = 0.106$ (*). (3) KDE-smoothed null: expected 64.9 ± 7.8, observed 88, $Z = 2.96$, $p = 0.003$ (*). Dome enrichment survives all three models. The geographic-concentration nulls (Null A, Null C; §4.2) show that proximity to harmonic longitudes is necessary but not sufficient to explain the dome enrichment.

5.6 Pipeline Portability: Wikidata Q180987 Stupa Corpus

The pipeline was applied to $N = 229$ Wikidata-attested stupas (class Q180987) independently of the UNESCO corpus (Tenenbaum, 2026). The Kedu Plain (Java) hosts the densest cluster at the 2.5-beru harmonic, anchored by Borobudur (c. 800 CE, 7.23 km, Tier A+) (Miksic, 1990); the World Peace Pagoda at Lumbini achieves A++ precision (∼555 m) uniquely from Gerizim.

Using the identical anchor and null, the corpus yields 70/229 Tier-A sites (30.6%, 1.53× null; binomial $p < 0.001$, ***; permutation $Z = 1.59$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.065$, ∼). No Tier-A+ enrichment is found ($p = 0.102$, ns), consistent with cluster-level rather than individual-site precision. Harmonic nodes with at least one Tier-A site carry 2.56× more stupa sites on average than empty nodes, mirroring the cluster-asymmetry result of Test 3.

Geographic tier breakdown and bimodal structure. A sub-regional breakdown reveals a bimodal pattern consistent with the Buddhist A/C enrichment in the UNESCO religion audit (§4.1). The Java/Sumatra node (105°–115°E, near the 2.5-beru harmonic at 110.3°E) concentrates 43 of 83 sites at Tier-A (51.8%, OR = 4.74×, $p = 0.000$ ***), rising to 42/54 (77.8%, OR = 18.38×, $p = 0.000$ ***) in the 107°–112°E window, where A+ is also elevated at 20.4% (OR = 4.72×, $p = 0.002$ **). The physical heartland, India/Nepal (70°–90°E) and Myanmar/Cambodia (90°–105°E), is A-tier depleted (OR = 0.15–0.68×, ns) but strongly enriched in the inter-harmonic C-band: Myanmar/Cambodia reaches 35.8% (OR = 4.47×, $p = 0.000$ ***) and the combined heartland 29.2% (OR = 6.00×, $p = 0.000$ ***). The anti-correlation is consistent with a grid-level account (see §7.2). The non-heartland Wikidata stupas (outside 70°–110°E, $N = 102$) show the same A-enriched, C-depleted profile as the UNESCO domed monument corpus: 50.0% reach Tier-A (OR = 5.68×, $p = 0.000$ ***) with no C-band enrichment (0.19×, $p = 1.000$ ns), suggesting that UNESCO inscription preferentially captures the most precisely aligned examples within each tradition.

5.7 Multiple Comparisons

See §3.6 for the full protocol. Gerizim ranks at the 98.0th percentile; a ±0.3% unit shift collapses joint significance. The meta-keyword test (1741 candidates) finds only 41 (2.4%) matching the curated set's enrichment. FDR audit (44 tests) retains 21 at $q < 0.05$; 6 survive Bonferroni at $k = 44$.

6 Limitations

6.1 Circularity: Full Canonical Treatment

Pre-registration cannot address circularity for analyses of permanent public databases. The UNESCO coordinate file and Mount Gerizim are both fully public, so any investigator could run this pipeline at any time and temporal priority is unverifiable. The relevant questions are whether the pattern exists and whether the anchor was chosen on independent grounds.

Both are answered directly. The global anchor sweep (§5.3) confirms that the enrichment is a property of the ∼35°E corridor. Every x.18°E anchor produces the same result, and Gerizim and Jerusalem both place the corridor in the global top 2.0% of 36,000 trial anchors. Historical justifications could be constructed post-hoc

for many high-scoring anchors in the global sweep. What distinguishes Gerizim is pre-existing documentary evidence, the *tabbur ha-aretz* cosmographic role (§2.3), that predates this analysis entirely.

The 3° periodic structure is recoverable by any unanchored 120-phase scan without reference to Gerizim. The dome enrichment (Test 2) is identical across all 120 x.18°E anchors. The cluster asymmetry (Test 3) requires no keyword filter and no anchor. Test B is tautological by construction (§4.4) and is noted as such.

The Levantine corridor statistics are reported as the motivated entry point, not independent confirmation. This ranking does not survive the 36,000-anchor discovery correction (Test E, $p = 0.0564$, †). The primary evidence is Tests 2 and 3, which require no anchor.

6.2 Geographic and Cultural Selection Bias

The UNESCO list over-represents Europe and the Mediterranean-to-South-Asian corridor of Cultural/Mixed sites. The regional distribution is as follows: (Europe & North America: 50%; Arab States: 9%; Asia-Pacific: 23%; Latin Americas: 11%; Africa: 7%). Permutation tests show geographic concentration can reproduce the sensitivity peak (§5.2), but domed monuments exceed the A+ rate of other monuments from the same longitude footprint (Null C, $p = 0.0394$, *), establishing that the enrichment is carried by a specific building type rather than the geographic distribution alone. Although UNESCO nomination criteria make no reference to longitude, it cannot be ruled out that the inscription process carries some of the same longitudinal structure observed here.

A Monte Carlo unit sweep (10000 permutations, 18 candidate spacing values from 0.5° to 15°) identifies which angular interval produces clustering beyond geographic concentration without assuming any particular unit. The dominant peak is at 3° ($p < 0.001$), with harmonics at 6° and 12° also significant; adjacent candidates 2.5° and 3.5° do not reach significance. Collapsing harmonics, the dome subset yields 2 independent dominant spacing ($P = 0.1951$ under the geographic null), supporting 3° as the period to which domed monuments are preferentially aligned.

6.3 Americas Negative Control

The UNESCO Americas sub-corpus ($N = 145$) shows directional depletion (A+ = 2.1%, $p = 0.4102$, ns) relative to the 6% null; the result is directional but uninformative at this sample size.

6.4 Other Limitations

Geocoding precision. UNESCO XML coordinates are administrative centroids, introducing unsystematic noise but not directional bias. Dome enrichment is robust across raw and context-validated populations and all three simulation nulls. The observed enrichment is not an artifact of site clustering.

Metrological evidence. No physical surveying instrument calibrated in beru subdivisions has been recovered; documentary sources attest the beru system (Hunger & Steele, 2019; Robson, 2008; Powell, 1987). This study therefore treats the coordinate alignment of Mount Gerizim as a novel empirical observation.

7 Discussion

7.1 Alternative Explanations

(1) Independent convergence. Hemispherical structures are a recurring architectural solution and convergent orientations across cultures are documented (Aveni, 2001, 2003), but independent convergence predicts no consistent longitude specificity.

(2) Geographic concentration. This is the strongest alternative and cannot be excluded on this corpus alone. Null C ($p = 0.0394$, *) shows other monuments at the same longitudes are significantly less enriched; the Monte Carlo unit sweep (§6.2) confirms 3° as the dominant angular period without assuming any unit.

(3) Random coincidence. Three simulation approaches fail to reproduce the dome enrichment (permutation $p = 0.095$; bootstrap $p = 0.106$). Tests C and D (§4.4) provide positive evidence for anchor specificity and periodicity structure.

7.2 Candidate Transmission Pathways

The statistical evidence does not identify a mechanism, but the geographic structure of the signal points toward the Buddhist tradition as the most tractable case. Within the dome-evolution corpus, the stupa sub-stage achieves an A+ rate of 22.2% (4/18 sites, OR = 3.09×, $p = 0.0637$ †), the highest of any keyword-defined sub-population in the analysis and more than five times the geometric null. Three of the four UNESCO A+ stupa sites fall in the 95°–110°E corridor, including Pyu Ancient Cities, Silk Roads Chang'an-Tianshan, and Borobudur (c. 800 CE) (Miksic, 1990). The fourth is Lumbini (83°E, Nepal). The Indonesia sub-region (95°–141°E) achieves an A+ rate of 60% (3/5 sites, OR = 26.97×, $p = 0.0015$, **). By contrast, the four C-tier stupa sites fall exclusively in the India/Pakistan band: Mahabodhi, Elephanta, Taxila, and Ajanta (OR = 3.44×, $p = 0.0974$ †). The Indian heartland's C-band enrichment is consistent with the Buddhist A/C bimodal identified in §4.1: India/Pakistan sites fall on 0.05-beru harmonics, while Indonesia and Southeast Asian sites align with the 0.10-beru grid. The Wikidata Q180987 stupa corpus (§5.6) reproduces the same pattern independently, with 30.6% of all 229 stupas reaching Tier-A (binomial $p < 0.001$ ***; permutation $Z = 1.59$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.065$ ∼), confirming corpus-wide harmonic enrichment. At the Java node (107°–112°E) the A-tier rate rises to 77.8% (OR = 18.38×, $p < 0.001$ ***), and Tier-A+ is also elevated: 20.4% (OR = 4.72×, $p = 0.002$ **). The C-band signal localizes to Myanmar and Cambodia (35.8%, OR = 4.47×, $p < 0.001$ ***) rather than the Indian subcontinent (Figure 4). The anti-correlation between the Indian heartland (C-band enriched, A-depleted) and the Southeast Asian transmission zone (A+ enriched, C-absent) is consistent with placement according to two nested grids: 0.05-beru in the tradition's origin region and 0.10-beru at its transmission nodes.

7.3 Conclusion

The UNESCO Cultural and Mixed corpus is quantized to the 0.1-beru (3°) longitude grid anchored at Gerizim, with the full-corpus enrichment surviving Bonferroni correction at $k = 3$. Longitude bands that contain a precisely aligned monument are 4.45× more densely populated with other heritage sites than bands without one (Test 3, $p = 0.0006$ ***), suggesting that the most important sites and the broader heritage record share the same longitudinal structure. Among architectural sub-populations, spherically shaped monuments show the strongest alignment of any

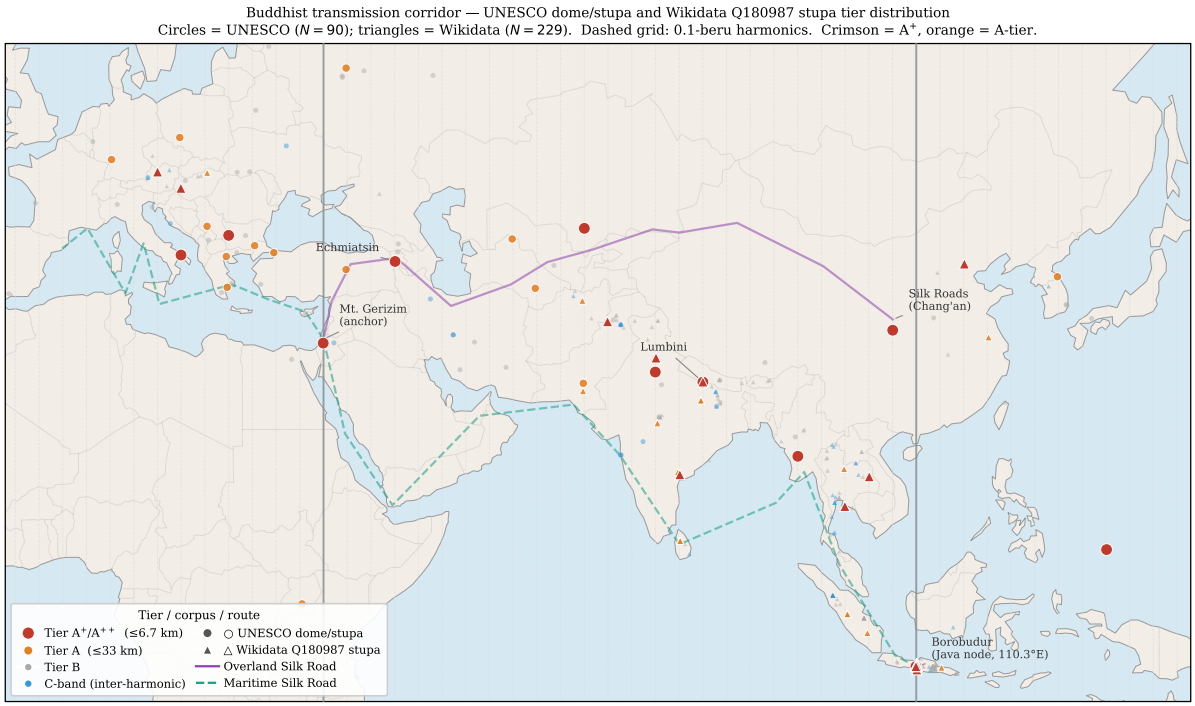

Figure 4: Tier distribution of UNESCO domed/stupa and Wikidata Q180987 stupas sites along the Silk Road corridor.

class tested (OR = 1.90, $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.015$ *), exceeding what geography alone predicts (Null C, $p = 0.0394$ *).

Comparison with the Wikidata Q180987 stupa corpus suggests a broader pattern: within the stupa tradition, the most historically significant monuments are those positioned at $x.18$°E harmonic longitudes, and UNESCO inscription appears to select preferentially from this aligned subset.

Geographically, Mount Gerizim lies between the Mediterranean to the west and the overland Silk Road to the east, placing it at a natural node of the corridors through which architectural canons circulated in antiquity (Figure 4).

Replication and methodological transferability

The pipeline is transferable to any externally curated corpus; the Wikidata Q180987 result (§5.6) illustrates one such application. Tier boundaries and the null model are fixed independently of the data, so further applications will either accumulate evidence or not.

A Keyword Audit Summary

Full site-by-site audit files are in the archived code repository (Tenenbaum 2026).

A.1 Dome/Spherical Monument Filter (Tests 2, 2b, 2x, 2bx)

7 morphological keywords from four roots (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*, *dome/domed/domes*, *spherical*) are matched as whole words against each site's name, XML description,

and extended OUV text. All 90 matching sites are included in Test 2 without context gating.

For Test 2x, ambiguous keywords (*dome, domed, domes, spherical*) are subject to a two-gate context check: Gate 1 (28 negative patterns) rejects non-architectural uses; Gate 2 (86 positive patterns) requires architectural confirmation. Unambiguous keywords (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*) are accepted without validation. The full gate lists are in `lib/dome_filter.py`. The seven rejected sites are: Hiroshima Peace Memorial, Richtersveld, Gyeongju, Viñales Valley, Rock Islands Southern Lagoon, Uluru-Kata Tjuṭa, and Diquís Stone Spheres.

Test 2b adds earthen mound-stage keywords (*tumulus, tumuli, barrow, barrows, kofun* unambiguous; *mound* context-validated) to trace the hemispherical tradition from burial mound through stupa to architectural dome. Test 2bx applies the same architectural context gates to the extended population. Statistics for all four variants are reported in §4.2 and §4.3.

A.2 Founding-Origin Classifier (Test 5, Post-Hoc)

Results. The classifier finds 34.1% of A+ sites carry a founding keyword versus 29.3% in the full corpus (OR = 1.28, $p = 0.179$ ns). This carries no weight in the primary evidential chain as the classifier was iteratively tuned after data inspection.

The founding-origin classifier (`lib/founding_filter.py`) assigns sites to five categories: Founding Capital (F), Sacred Origin (S), Founding Monument (M), Founding Axis (X), and Ancient Continuous Landscape (L). Each category has its own unambiguous keyword set plus context-gated ambiguous terms; positive and negative gate patterns are defined per category in `keywords.json`. The classifier was iteratively tuned after data inspection to reduce false positives; residual interpretive ambiguity at the boundary between founding-related and general heritage descriptions is accepted. Statistics are reported in §**??**; the full site-by-site listing is in `supplementary/audit/founding_keyword_audit.txt`.

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Data Availability Statement

All data and analysis code are openly available. A permanent archival snapshot (v1.1.0) is deposited at Zenodo (Tenenbaum 2026; https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19599676).

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Conflict of Interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

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